Traditional Board Games of India

Knowledge document 090 of 100

Introduction

India has an ancient and rich tradition of board games, some of which spread across the world and became modern favourites. Games were played in royal courts and village courtyards and carried moral, strategic and spiritual meaning. They have been found in the archaeological record: boards scratched in stone at Indus Valley sites, temple floors and forts, and dice, gaming pieces and boards are among the Harappan finds. Board games are mentioned in the Rig Veda and the Mahabharata, in which the Pandavas lost their kingdom to the Kauravas in a game of dice, called chausar or pasha. These games taught mathematics, planning and patience and are enjoyed at festivals and family gatherings.

What Is Pallanguzhi?

Pallanguzhi is a traditional board game of Tamil Nadu, and one of the best-known members of the "mancala" family of sowing and capturing games found across Africa and Asia. The name means "many pits" in Tamil ("pallam" means pit or hollow and "kuzhi" means pit). The board is a wooden board, often with a hinged, foldable case, with two rows of seven pits, so fourteen pits in total, and in each pit are placed a number of seeds, usually five or six depending on the variant, using tamarind seeds, cowrie shells or small pebbles. It is played by two players, each owning the row of seven pits on his or her side. A player picks up all the seeds from one of the pits and sows them one by one in the following pits anticlockwise. When the last seed falls in a pit, the player continues by picking up the seeds of the next pit, and goes on until the next pit is empty, whereupon the player captures the seeds of the pit after the empty one. The player who collects the most seeds wins. The game is full of mental calculation and counting, which develops arithmetic. It is also said to be an old game, mentioned in Tamil traditions and found carved in stone at temples, such as in Hampi, and was traditionally played by women and children at home. There are variations known as Vamana Guntalu in Telugu, Alli Guli Mane in Kannada and Kuzhipara in Malayalam. In Tamil Nadu, there are also many other rural games like Aadu Puli Attam, Dayakattai and Tayam.

Chaturanga, Chess and Pachisi

Chaturanga, from which chess evolved, was invented in India around the 6th century CE, and spread to Persia, the Arab world and Europe. Its name means "four limbs" of the army. The game of Pachisi, from the Hindi word pachis, meaning twenty-five, the highest throw with cowrie shells, is played on a cross-shaped board by four players, who move pieces around the board according to throws of cowrie shells or dice. It is an ancient game, mentioned in the Mahabharata in some forms, and the Mughal emperor Akbar played a life-sized version at Fatehpur Sikri, in which girls dressed in colours acted as pieces on a courtyard inlaid in a cross shape. A simplified version of Pachisi, called Chaupar, uses dice.

Which Modern Game Came From Pachisi?

Ludo, the popular modern board game, came from Pachisi. In England, in 1896, Alfred Collier patented a simplified version of the game as "Ludo", which is Latin for "I play", and it was marketed in the Victorian era. Another version, Parcheesi, was sold in the United States from 1867. Ludo is played by two to four players, who throw a die and move four tokens each around a cross-shaped board, to reach the centre, and is as popular in Indian homes as it was in past centuries, and ludo apps are now among the most downloaded games.

What Is Paramapadam?

Paramapadam is the Tamil name of the traditional Indian board game that became Snakes and Ladders. The name means "the final abode" or "the highest state", referring to Vaikuntha, the abode of Vishnu, which is the goal of the game. The original game, called Moksha Patam or Mokshapat in Hindi and Marathi, and Gyan Chauper, meaning "game of knowledge", was created in ancient India, and used for moral teaching, perhaps by the poet-saint Gyandev in the 13th century. The board has numbered squares, in which ladders represent virtues such as generosity, faith and humility, which lift a player up toward moksha (liberation), and snakes represent vices such as lust, anger, murder and theft, which take the player down, back toward rebirth. A traditional board had more snakes than ladders, to show that the path of vice is easier than the path of virtue, and the final square is the heaven. The game was taken to England by the British in the 1890s, and became Snakes and Ladders, and in 1943 Milton Bradley in the United States made it Chutes and Ladders. In Tamil Nadu, Paramapadam is played during festivals, such as Vaikuntha Ekadashi, when families stay awake and play the game, and the Tamil version has a board with images of the gods.

Other Traditional Games

Aadu Puli Attam, also known as the "goats and tigers" game, is a strategy game from Tamil Nadu in which three tigers hunt fifteen goats on a triangular board. Dayakattai and Chowka Bara (Ashta Chamma) are dice and cowrie games in squares of five by five. Navakankari is a game similar to Nine Men's Morris. Chaupar and Daayam, played with long dice, were the games of kings. Gilli-danda and kancha (marbles) are outdoor games. Games are used in schools to teach mathematics, and the Indian government promotes them through the Khelo India and tourism programmes.

Benefits and Preservation

Traditional games build mental skills, social bonds and cultural values, without screens. They are becoming less common with the rise of video games. Museums, festivals and craftspeople in Tamil Nadu, such as makers of wooden Pallanguzhi boards in Karaikudi, keep the tradition alive.

Challenges and Future

The challenge is to attract young people. Digital versions, school activities and tournaments are helping these games to be popular again.

Quick Facts

- Pallanguzhi is a Tamil mancala-type game with two rows of seven pits, played with seeds or shells.
- Ludo came from the ancient Indian game Pachisi; chess evolved from Chaturanga.
- Paramapadam is the Tamil name of the ancient game that became Snakes and Ladders.
- In Paramapadam ladders represent virtues and snakes represent vices.
- Pachisi was played by the Mughal emperor Akbar on a life-sized court at Fatehpur Sikri.